

Ethics Week 4 — Quiz Prep

Generative AI, Consent and Power

Dr Tina L. Peterson · ECS7025P · 20 February 2026

51%

of novelists think AI will
replace them

59%

know work used to train
LLMs without consent

85%

expect future income
driven down by AI

1,000+

musicians protesting UK
copyright changes

This document covers everything from the lecture and all three assigned readings. Designed for quiz prep — key concepts, definitions, stats, and likely quiz questions.

1. Core Concepts from the Lecture

Consent (in the context of Gen AI)

Consent means **voluntary, informed agreement** to a specific use of your work or likeness. In the context of generative AI, consent is often **conditional or forced** — creators must post work online to sell it, but they did not consent to having it scraped for AI training data.

■ Key Definition — Consent in AI Context

- **True consent** = voluntary, informed, specific, revocable
- **Conditional consent** = "I consent to sharing my art online, NOT to AI scraping it"
- **Forced consent** = creators **MUST** be online to earn a living → no real choice about scraping
- Posting online ≠ consenting to AI training. Consent is conditional and context-specific.

Power & Abstracted Power

Power (related to Gen AI) = **control over the terms of another person's consent**.

AI companies control the terms — they scrape first, ask later (if at all). Individual creators have almost no power to prevent it.

■ Key Definition — Abstracted Power

- "A human actor's influence or control over a system, process, or dataset which, as a function of the technology that enables it, **obscures or distances the human actor from consequences** of that influence or control."
- — Peterson, Ferreira & Vardi (2023), IEEE Transactions on Technology and Society
- Technology creates **psychological distance** between action and consequence
- Makes people **feel less responsible** for harm they cause

How Technology Changes Our Sense of Responsibility

The lecture compared different interaction modes to show how technology creates distance:

Interaction	Distance	Sense of Responsibility
Face-to-face conversation	None	Highest
Texting someone	Low	High
Playing a board game together	None	High
Gaming space interaction	Medium	Medium
Social media comment	High	Lower
Scraping someone's data via API	Very High	Lowest

The Trolley Problem "With a Twist"

The lecture used a modified trolley problem to illustrate abstracted power — when the mechanism between your action and its consequence becomes more complex/technological, people feel less

responsible even though the outcome is identical.

■ Key Lecture Analogies — Physical vs Digital

- Taking a painting from an artist's shop → **clearly theft**
- Scraping digital images from their website → **same thing, but feels different**
- Taking a musician's CD without paying → **clearly theft**
- Downloading tracks to remix and sell → **same thing, technology creates distance**
- Taking photos from someone's home → **clearly a violation**
- Scraping profile photos from social media → **same violation, normalised by technology**

■ The Lecture's Core Rule

- **"If you wouldn't do it in person, you shouldn't do it using technology."**
- Technology can give us power over others while making us feel less responsible for how we impact them.

Non-Consensual Sexual Deepfakes

The lecture identified this as **"one of the most serious abuses of abstracted power and generative AI"**:

- Creates realistic, believable images/videos of real people
- Can **haunt and re-traumatise** victims forever
- Law enforcement increasingly calling it **"virtual rape"**
- A clear example of abstracted power: technology distances the perpetrator from the harm

2. Article 1: Silent Album Protest (BBC)

"Artists release silent album in protest against AI using their work" — BBC News

■ Key Facts You Must Know

- **1,000+ musicians** including Annie Lennox, Kate Bush, Damon Albarn, Hans Zimmer, Imogen Heap released a **silent album**
- Album title: **"Is This What We Want?"** — tracklisting spells out: "The British government must not legalise music theft to benefit AI companies"
- Features recordings of **empty studios and performance spaces** — what they fear the future looks like
- Profits donated to **Help Musicians** charity
- Part of the **"Make It Fair"** campaign with wrap-around newspaper adverts

What's the Policy Issue?

The UK government proposed changes to copyright law:

- AI developers would be able to use **any content available online** for text/data mining
- Artists would have a **"rights reservation"** — the ability to opt out
- Critics say opt-out is **impractical**: impossible for one artist to notify thousands of AI companies
- Cannot monitor what happened to their work across the entire internet
- UK music contributed **£7.6 billion** to the economy in 2023

■ Connection to Lecture Concepts

- **Consent**: Artists consent to sharing music online, NOT to AI scraping — conditional consent violated
- **Abstracted power**: AI companies scrape at scale, individual artists powerless to prevent it
- **Opt-out vs opt-in**: Government proposes opt-out (burden on artists) instead of opt-in (burden on AI companies) — who holds the power?
- **Paul McCartney quote**: Could make it "impossible for musicians and artists to make a living"

3. Article 2: UK Novelists & AI (Cambridge)

"Half of UK novelists believe AI is likely to replace their work entirely" — University of Cambridge

Key Statistics (likely quiz material)

Statistic	Value	What It Means
Novelists who think AI will replace them	51%	Majority believe full displacement is likely
Know work used to train LLMs without consent	59%	Most are aware of unauthorised scraping
Income already hit by AI	39%	Over a third already affected financially
Expect future income driven down	85%	Near-universal pessimism about earnings
Use AI in their writing process	33%	A third use it (mainly non-creative tasks)
Agree AI offers benefits to society	80%	NOT anti-AI — nuanced view
Romance authors "extremely threatened"	66%	Genre fiction most vulnerable
Thriller authors "extremely threatened"	61%	Formulaic genres easier to replicate
Crime authors "extremely threatened"	60%	Pattern-based genres at highest risk

■ Connection to Lecture Concepts

- **Consent:** 59% know their work was scraped without consent — "the brutal irony is GenAI tools affecting novelists are likely trained on millions of pirated novels"
- **Power asymmetry:** Individual authors vs billion-dollar tech companies — no meaningful ability to prevent scraping
- **Conditional consent:** Authors publish books to be READ, not to train AI. Context matters.
- **Key nuance:** 80% agree AI has societal benefits — they're not anti-technology, they're anti-exploitation
- **What they want:** Informed consent, fair remuneration, transparency from tech companies
- **UK publishing exports more books than any other country** — £11bn annual contribution

AI Tools Mentioned in the Article

- **Sudowrite, Novelcrafter** — brainstorm and edit novels
- **Qyx AI Book Creator, Squibler** — draft full-length books
- **Spines** — AI-assisted publishing (cover design to distribution)

4. Article 3: Non-Consensual Deepfakes (Digital Watch)

"Non-consensual deepfakes, consent, and power in synthetic media" — Digital Watch Observatory

■ Key Concepts

- **AI pornography** = using generative AI to create/manipulate sexual content of real people without consent
- **Nudify apps** = tools that digitally remove clothing from photos of real people
- **Deepfake pornography** = realistic fake sexual videos/images using someone's likeness
- What was once niche has become a **global policy concern**
- Consent reduced to a **"technical obstacle"** rather than treated as a social principle

Why This Is Different from Traditional Pornography

- Traditional pornography: involves **real performers, production, contracts** (even where exploitation exists)
- AI-generated: **simulates** acts using algorithmic inference — the subject may **never have participated**
- Faces, bodies, voices can be **reconstructed at scale** without knowledge or consent
- Results can be **indistinguishable from real photos**
- Once created, content can be **replicated endlessly** across jurisdictions

Who Is Most Affected?

- **Women and girls** are disproportionately targeted
- Public figures, journalists, politicians, and private individuals all targeted
- Used to **humiliate, intimidate, or silence** victims
- **Children** face extreme risk — AI can generate sexualised images of minors
- Even without physical abuse, may constitute **child sexual abuse material** legally

The Grok Controversy

Elon Musk's Grok AI was reported to generate/modify sexualised images of women and children. Despite claimed safeguards, repeated abusive outputs suggest **systemic design failures, not isolated misuse**.

Legal Responses

- **US Take It Down Act** — recognises non-consensual synthetic sexual content as a distinct category of abuse
- Law enforcement increasingly calls it **"virtual rape"** (also mentioned in lecture)
- Legal systems struggle: built around **physical acts**, not synthetic representation
- Harm arises through **exposure, distribution, psychological impact** — not just physical contact

■ Connection to Lecture Concepts

- **Abstracted power at its worst:** Perpetrator is completely distanced from victim — clicks a button, ruins a life
- **Consent obliterated:** Subject never participated in ANY sexual act yet content looks authentic
- **Technology as force multiplier:** One person can victimise thousands using AI tools
- **The lecture's test:** "If you wouldn't do it in person, don't do it with technology" — nobody would do this face-to-face

5. Likely Quiz Questions & How to Answer

Based on lecture structure and reading themes, expect questions like:

Likely Question	Key Points for Your Answer
Define consent in the context of generative AI	Voluntary, informed agreement to specific use. Posting online ≠ consent to AI scraping. Co
What is abstracted power?	Peterson et al. (2023): influence/control over a system that obscures/distances the actor fr
How does technology change our sense of responsibility?	Psychological distance = less felt responsibility. Face-to-face (high) → API scraping (l
What is the "opt-out" debate?	UK gov proposes creators opt-out of AI scraping. Critics: impractical for individuals vs thou
Why did musicians release a silent album?	1,000+ artists protesting UK copyright changes. Album "Is This What We Want?" with emp
What did the Cambridge study on novelists find?	51% think AI will replace them. 59% know work scraped without consent. 85% expect incor
Which genres are most threatened by AI?	Romance (66%), thrillers (61%), crime (60%) — formulaic, pattern-based genres are easie
What are non-consensual deepfakes?	AI-generated sexual content using real people's likeness without consent. Nudify apps, dee
How is AI pornography different from traditional?	No real performers needed. Subject may never have participated. Content indistinguishabl
What was the Grok controversy?	Musk's AI generated sexualised images of women/children. Systemic design failure, not iso
Give an example of the lecture's analogy about theft	Taking a painting from a shop = clearly theft. Scraping digital art from a website = same vic
What legal responses exist to deepfakes?	US Take It Down Act. "Virtual rape" classification. Challenge: legal systems built around ph

6. One-Page Cheat Sheet

■ DEFINITIONS

- **Consent** = voluntary, informed, specific agreement. Posting online ≠ AI consent.
- **Abstracted power** = tech-enabled control that distances actor from consequences (Peterson et al. 2023)
- **Conditional consent** = "I consent to X but NOT Y" — scraping violates the condition
- **Deepfake** = AI-generated realistic fake image/video of a real person
- **Nudify app** = AI tool that digitally removes clothing from photos

■ KEY STATS

- **51%** of UK novelists think AI will fully replace them (Cambridge)
- **59%** know work used to train LLMs without consent
- **85%** expect income to decline due to AI
- **80%** agree AI has societal benefits (nuanced, NOT anti-tech)
- **33%** use AI for non-creative tasks in writing
- **66%** say romance authors are "extremely threatened"
- **1,000+** musicians released silent album protesting UK copyright changes
- **£7.6bn** UK music industry contribution (2023), **£11bn** publishing

■ CONNECTING THEMES

- **All three articles** are about CONSENT being violated by AI companies
- **Power asymmetry**: individuals vs tech giants — creators have no real choice
- **Abstracted power** makes scraping/deepfakes feel "victimless" — but victims are real
- **Opt-out vs opt-in**: who bears the burden? Currently creators, not companies.
- **The test**: "If you wouldn't do it in person, don't do it with technology"
- **Genre fiction + formulaic content** most at risk (romance, thrillers, crime)
- **Women and girls** disproportionately targeted by deepfakes
- **Legal systems** struggling to catch up — built for physical harm, not synthetic

■ KEY PEOPLE & SOURCES

- **Dr Tina L. Peterson** — lecturer, coined "abstracted power" (IEEE 2023)
- **Dr Clementine Collett** — Cambridge researcher, novelists study
- **Darren Lewis / Future Cut** — guest speaker, songwriter/producer (50M+ album sales)
- **Ed Newton-Rex** — organised the silent album protest
- **Paul McCartney** — called copyright changes "rip off" technology